As for the BJP, the loss of face was in sum greater than the quantifiable damages. Yes, its tally declined from 23 in 2019 to nine and three of its Union ministers—Raosaheb Patil Danve, Kapil Patil and Bharati Pawar—were trounced. But in the end, it was a defeat on the plane of strategy itself. On June 5, deputy CM Devendra Fadnavis, who led the Mahayuti's campaign in the state, offered to quit and focus on the organisation. The announcement, says a senior BJP leader, could have been aimed at persuading Shinde, Ajit and even leaders from his own party in other states who delivered a sub-par performance, to do likewise. BJP sources also argue that the political compulsion to set aside 15 seats for Shinde to prove his faction was the 'real' Shiv Sena cost the Mahayuti dear.

On his part, Shinde has blamed the Mahayuti's poor performance on the Opposition's *"apaprachar"* (fake propaganda) that the BJP would change the Constitution if elected to power, and the inability to counter this narrative. His partymen also allege that BJP leaders did not work for their candidates, affecting the transfer of their core votes.

Away from the official line, there is introspection within BJP circles too. "Many of our traditional voters have not liked the decision to take Ajit Pawar along; we have accused him of graft in the past," says a senior party leader. He points to the resentment among old-timers about the state unit turning into an unwieldy directory of defectors, with the rise of businessmen-politicians sans a mass base at the cost of loyalists. "Overall, the narrative had slipped out of our hands... They were using a sword while we were defending ourselves with a shield."

Another former minister close to the BJP adds more reasons—the top leadership's reluctance to drop some sitting MPs to mitigate local anti-incumbency and the strong narrative about agencies like the Enforcement Directorate being deployed against political rivals.

The echoes of such introspection can be heard within the Ajit faction of the NCP too. "The politics of splitting parties, the sympathy for Thackeray and Pawar, the perceived arrogance of our leaders and agrarian distress have led to this debacle," confesses a senior Ajit faction minister. He even credits Shinde's performance as beyond expectations, given that it had a strike rate of 46 per cent compared to the BJP's 39 per cent. For this reason, he feels, the senior ally will not be able to do away with Shinde, as some had predicted..

There are niggles for Sena(UBT) too. It has faced shock losses in strongholds like Raigad and Ratnagiri-Sindhudurg. In Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar (Aurangabad), Sandipan Bhumre of the Shinde Sena, who is a Maratha, defeated old SS(UBT) war horse Chandrakant Khaire, a Dalit, due to a crystallisation of Maratha votes. It also lost the Mumbai North West seat to Shinde's Sena by just 48 votes. The Election Commission's grant of the Shiv Sena's bow and arrow symbol to the Shinde Sena may have confused some voters in urban pockets, claim SS(UBT) leaders.

What SS(UBT) has managed to do is expand its social base. In Mumbai, while its traditional Maratha voters may have backed Shinde or the BJP's nominees as well, the support of the Muslims in the Maratha-Muslim (MaMu) combination compensated for this attrition. In Marathwada, where the party had a bristling relationship with Muslims as evidenced by the slogan *'Khan hava ka baan hava?'* (do you want the Khan or the bow and arrow symbol?), Muslim support for Thackeray saved the day, along with that of Marathas and Dalits. According to senior journalist Devendra Gawande, the DMK (Dalit, Muslim, Kunbi) combination had coalesced in the MVA's favour in Vidarbha.

As senior journalist Vijay Chormare says, it is the assembly polls that will determine the real Sena and NCP as the number of seats involved is significantly higher. Meanwhile, a few imponderables remain. Will the BJP ask Shinde to make way for a fresh face from his party, preferably from the dominant Maratha community? Will the BJP contest the assembly election on its own strength? Will the prodigal nephew return to the Pawar Sr camp? ■

AFTER THE BATTLE

WINNERS



Supriya Sule
NCP(SP)
Baramati



Shrikant Shinde
Shiv Sena
Kalyan



Piyush Goyal
BJP
Mumbai North



Anil Desai
SS(UBT)
Mumbai South Central

LOSERS



Sudhir Mungantiwar *BJP*
Chandrapur



Navneet Kaur Rana *BJP*
Amravati



Ujjwal Nikam *BJP*
Mumbai North Central



Dr Bharati Pawar
BJP
Dindori